Citation indexing

Dear Sir,

If *Citation Indexing* reviewed in *Journal of Information Science* 1(5) (1979), were written under ideal circumstances, I would have sent an advance copy to persons like Charles Oppenheim. These reviewers could then have pointed out all the missing references and made other comments concerning the kind of book *they* would have written. In fact, it would be nice for an author to have comments from *all* potential readers. Theoretically, the published book would then be ideal. But by the time all the revisions were incorporated, you would have a new book that needed to be reviewed all over again. What eventually got published would be even more obsolete than the average book is today.

However, *Citation Indexing* was not written under ideal conditions. The writing effort spanned more years than I care to admit. And towards the end, the pressure on me to release the manuscript to the publisher was enormous. Be that as it may, it is true that *Citation Indexing* is not as complete as Charles would like. But there is now an awful lot of literature on citation indexing and citation analysis. I don't think readers need to be told about that vast literature *in toto*. Those who are interested will have little trouble expanding their readings – if by no other means than by using the appropriate citation index. Besides, the book was not intended as a "comprehensive review" of the literature, but as a review of the subject as I knew it.

Maybe the next version of *Citation Indexing* will be a better book. In the meantime, to quote Charles, the present edition was needed to "fill the gap" for those who want a textbook on citation indexing.

Yours truly,
Eugene Garfield
President, Institute for Scientific Information
Philadelphia, U.S.A.

Computers and patentability

Dear Sir,

In the October 1978 issue of this journal [1], Alan Blick discusses some potential effects on patentability of synthetic routes in organic chemistry, as a result of increasingly widespread use of program packages for computer-aided synthetic planning.

Some analogous issues were raised some years ago with regard to the prediction of biological activities from a consideration of structure-activity relationships, by a committee of IUPAC's Section of Medicinal Chemistry [2]. Their major concern was that publication of predicted activities, although the compounds might not have been tested, or even synthesised, could invalidate any future patent. With the increasing practicability of "automatic" structure-activity analysis, with pattern recognition and similar techniques applied across computerised data-banks, such problems may become more prominent.

One important distinction between this issue and that of computer-aided synthesis, is the proprietary nature of the information used in many structure-activity studies. Nevertheless, it may well be that problems of this sort will arise with many applications of 'expert systems' for information retrieval and analysis.

[1] A. Blick, J. Information Sci. 1 (1979) 227.
[2] L.G. Humber et al., IUPAC Information Bull. 12 (1975)

Yours
David Bawden
Central Research
Pfizer
Sandwich
Kent CT13 9NJ
United Kingdom

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